Era 1: Indigenous America

to 1491 · APUSH Period 1 · Lessons 1–1

Name _____ Due _____

This is your study guide for the whole era. Complete each lesson section as you study it, using your class notes and textbook: read the AP topic(s) listed for the lesson in your textbook, define every term, person and event in your own words, then answer the Key Question in 3–5 sentences with specific evidence. Each lesson is checked and stamped in class; the whole guide is collected and graded at the end of the era. **Before the end-of-era test:** finish the Era Wrap-Up, then reread the whole guide. Fix or add anything in a different color.

Lesson 1 *Pre-Columbian societies · environment & culture*

1.2 (LO B): Explain how and why various native populations in the period before European contact interacted with the natural environment in North America.

Read (AP topic in your textbook): Topic 1.2 *Native American Societies Before European Contact*

STAMP

Terms

Define it in your own words and explain why it matters.

1. **maize cultivation**

2. **Three Sisters agriculture**

3. **Mississippian culture**

4. **Great Plains nomads**

5. **kinship networks**

6. **matrilineal society**

7. **oral tradition**

8. **Bering land bridge**

9. **Tenochtitlán**

People

Who they were and why they matter.

10. **Pueblo peoples (Ancestral Pueblo)**

11. **Chinookan peoples**

12. **Algonquian peoples**

13. **Plains peoples**

14. **Aztec (Mexica)**

15. **Inca**

16. **Pacific Northwest peoples**

17. Great Basin peoples

Events

What happened and why it matters.

18. rise of Cahokia (c. 1050–1350)

19. Mesa Verde cliff dwellings (1190s)

20. Iroquois Confederacy forms (c. 1450)

Lesson 1 · Key Question *Pre-Columbian societies · environment & culture*

1.2 (LO B): Explain how and why various native populations in the period before European contact interacted with the natural environment in North America.

Explain how the natural environment shaped the economies, social structures, and ways of life of different American Indian societies in North America before 1492.

Answer in 3–5 sentences. Make a clear claim, support it with at least two specific pieces of evidence from this lesson, and explain how the evidence supports your claim.

Era Wrap-Up *complete before the end-of-era test*

Native Societies and Their Environments

Region & peoples	Environment	Economy & food	Society & government
Southwest (Ancestral Pueblo)			
Great Plains			
Great Basin			
Pacific Northwest (incl. Chinookan peoples)			
Mississippi Valley (Mississippian / Cahokia)			
Northeast (Haudenosaunee & Algonquian peoples)			

AP Short-Answer Practice

Answer a, b and c. Each part is scored on its own, so answer each one directly in 1–3 sentences with specific historical evidence.

The Great Law of Peace of the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy, an oral constitution of the Five Nations, as later written down in English and published by Arthur C. Parker, The Constitution of the Five Nations, 1916 (sections 2 and 44)

Roots have spread out from the Tree of the Great Peace, one to the north, one to the east, one to the south and one to the west. The name of these roots is The Great White Roots and their nature is Peace and Strength.

If any man or any nation outside the Five Nations shall obey the laws of the Great Peace and make known their disposition to the Lords of the Confederacy, they may trace the Roots to the Tree and if their minds are clean and they are obedient and promise to obey the wishes of the Confederate Council, they shall be welcomed to take shelter beneath the Tree of the Long Leaves.

[. . .]

The lineal descent of the people of the Five Nations shall run in the female line. Women shall be considered the progenitors of the Nation. They shall own the land and the soil. Men and women shall follow the status of the mother.

Text: Arthur C. Parker, The Constitution of the Five Nations, New York State Museum Bulletin 184 (Albany, 1916), via Internet Archive. Excerpt: sections 2 and 44.

a. Briefly describe ONE feature of Haudenosaunee government or society expressed in the excerpt.

b. Briefly explain ONE reason the Five Nations joined together in a confederacy.

c. Briefly explain ONE way another American Indian society in North America before 1492 adapted to its environment differently from the Haudenosaunee.

DBQ Practice · Thesis

PROMPT

Evaluate the extent to which the natural environment shaped the development of American Indian societies in North America before 1492.

Your task: Write a thesis statement that responds to the prompt. You may use the document on this page as a reference, but your thesis must answer the prompt about North American societies before 1492.

What earns the point: To earn the point, your thesis must make a historically defensible claim and establish a line of reasoning: it should answer the question and preview the reasons you would use to support it. It must be one or more sentences in one place, not just a restatement of the prompt.

Christopher Columbus, journal of his first voyage, entry of October 11–12, 1492, describing the Taíno people he met at his first landfall in the Bahamas (the journal survives in an abstract made by Bartolomé de las Casas)

They go as naked as when their mothers bore them, and so do the women, although I did not see more than one young girl. All I saw were youths, none more than thirty years of age. They are very well made, with very handsome bodies, and very good countenances.

[. . .]

They neither carry nor know anything of arms, for I showed them swords, and they took them by the blade and cut themselves through ignorance. They have no iron, their darts being wands without iron, some of them having a fish's tooth at the end, and others being pointed in various ways.

[. . .]

They should be good servants and intelligent, for I observed that they quickly took in what was said to them, and I believe that they would easily be made Christians, as it appeared to me that they had no religion.

[. . .]

Text: Clements R. Markham, ed. and trans., The Journal of Christopher Columbus (London, 1893), as reproduced in The American Yawp Reader. Excerpt.

Connect forward — *Era 2 preview: Columbus judged the Taíno by European standards on the very first day of contact. Watch how those assumptions, along with disease, shaped what happened to Native societies after 1492.*